

STUDY GUIDE

UNITED NATIONS COMMISSION ON THE STATUS OF WOMEN



Agenda 01: Enhancing Women's Labour Force Participation and Financial Autonomy

Agenda 02: Assessing the Status and Representation of Women in Media





Letter from R&D

Dear Delegates,

It gives the Department of Research & Development, MUN Society MPSTME, immense pleasure to welcome you to the 12th edition of Mumbai MUN! True to our legacy, we remain committed to upholding and building upon a tradition of fostering informed discussions on matters of widespread concern.

We are primarily responsible for formulating relevant agendas and developing study guides that aim at imparting a holistic understanding of the issues at hand. This document has been prepared with a *first principles* approach, meant to play a part in orienting the committee discussions towards one that rises above the convention, and is characterised by substantiveness and inclusivity.

This year's theme, 'Voice Amidst the Void,' stands to remind us that when ideals fade into absence, voices must prevail. In an increasingly complex world, with an absence of conviction and shared purpose, we believe that the introduction of new ideas and impactful discourse is the need of the hour. True progress requires us to have the courage and willingness to speak up, have our perspectives heard, and to make sure that no voice is lost amidst a void of apathy.

Keeping this theme in mind, we have deliberately curated committees and agendas that focus on issues often overlooked in global conversations, in order to foster meaningful dialogue and resolution where it is most needed. In this study guide, you will find well-researched background information to help you prepare for your committee sessions. As facilitators, our aim is to equip you with the resources and insights you need to make the most out of your experience at Mumbai MUN.

We look forward to your active participation and contributions during Mumbai MUN and are confident that, together, we can make this conference an inspiring, enriching, and especially memorable experience for all.

Best wishes,

Department of Research & Development,
MUNSociety MPSTME.

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Agenda 1: Enhancing Women's Labour Force Participation and Financial Autonomy

COMMITTEE OVERVIEW

The UN Commission on the Status of Women (UNCSW) is a functional commission of the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC), one of the principal organs of the UN. CSW has been described as the UN organ responsible for promoting gender equality and the empowerment of women. It was established on 21 June 1946.

The CSW is instrumental in promoting women's and girls' rights, documenting the realities of their lives worldwide, and shaping global standards on gender equality and the empowerment of women and girls.

In 1996, ECOSOC, in resolution 1996/6, expanded the Commission's mandate and decided that it should take a leading role in monitoring and reviewing progress and problems in the implementation of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, as well as in mainstreaming a gender perspective in UN activities.¹

AGENDA OVERVIEW

An increase in the number of working women can offer significant social and economic benefits globally. However, social norms and traditions, as well as legal and institutional barriers, often prevent women from entering the workforce in many developing countries. Cultural norms prevent women from realising their full economic potential, and safety concerns restrict their physical and economic mobility. Additionally, gender inequities and the lack of enabling conditions in the workplace make it

more difficult for women to participate in the labour market actively.

Financial autonomy empowers women to take control of their lives, making their own decisions, pursuing education and career opportunities, and ultimately enhancing their overall quality of life. Financial empowerment allows them to invest in their children's education, healthcare, and nutrition, leading to healthier and more prosperous families. Empowering women financially is not merely a social imperative but an economic necessity, thus contributing to a more equitable and prosperous society.

Thus, the agenda focuses on women's participation in the labour force and the need for financial autonomy, examining the barriers that limit progress and its impact on women, the economy and society as a whole.

INTRODUCTION

For decades, women's labour force participation and their financial autonomy have been key topics in global discourse. Despite the adoption of several resolutions and the establishment of various initiatives regarding these issues, there still remain significant disparities.

Although the rate of participation of women in the labour force is growing, their overall representation is still relatively low. The global labour force participation rate for women is just over 50% compared to 80% for men.² The lower rate of women's participation in the labour force compared to men is due to the social and cultural

¹ *Commission on the status of women*. UN Women – Headquarters. (n.d.). <https://www.unwomen.org/en/how-we-work/commission-on-the-status-of-women>

² WorldBank. (n.d.). *Female Labor Force Participation*. World Bank Gender Data Portal. <https://genderdata.worldbank.org/en/data-stories/flfp-data-story>

norms, pay gap between men and women, lack of safety and other such factors acting as barriers.

Financial autonomy helps women become more independent. As they earn and start saving for themselves, they can make their own decisions in education, healthcare, childcare and more. This reduces their dependency on others and helps in the development of society as well. Lack of financial literacy, social and cultural norms, workplace discrimination, and more are the reasons women are unable to achieve financial autonomy.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

Industrial Revolution

In 1760, as industrialisation swept across nations, factories emerged as the epicentres of economic activity. Women formed a significant portion of the industrial workforce, labouring in textile mills, factories, and workshops. Often working long hours in harsh conditions, these women contributed immensely to the burgeoning industrial economy. Despite facing lower wages and limited opportunities for advancement compared to their male counterparts, their labour was essential for the success of industrial enterprises.

Women emerged as agents of change during the Industrial Revolution. Inspired by their experiences in the workforce and motivated by a desire for social justice, many women became involved in activism and reform movements. From advocating for labour rights to fighting for women's suffrage, these trailblazing individuals challenged societal norms and pushed for meaningful change.

The Industrial Revolution also witnessed the proliferation of women's organisations dedicated to education, empowerment, and social reform. Institutions such as women's suffrage societies, temperance unions, and educational associations provided women with platforms to voice their concerns, advocate for their rights, and effect positive change in their communities. These organisations played a pivotal role in advancing the status of women and shaping the trajectory of social progress during the Industrial Revolution and beyond.³

World War 1

During WWI (1914-1918), large numbers of women were recruited into jobs vacated by men who had gone to fight in the war. New jobs were also created as part of the war effort, for example, in munitions factories. The high demand for weapons resulted in these munitions factories becoming the largest single employer of women during 1918. Though there was initial resistance to hiring women for what was seen as 'men's work', the introduction of conscription in 1916 made the need for women workers urgent.



Women Working During World War 1.
Source: Getty Images

This led to women holding jobs in areas of work that were formerly reserved for men, for example, as railway guards and ticket collectors,

³ Datt, A. (2024a, March 15). *Women's role in the Industrial Revolution: From workers to Reformers*. Thomas Earnshaw. https://thomas-earnshaw.com/blogs/the-earnshaw-odyssey/womens-role-in-the-industrial-revolution-from-factory-workers-to-reformers?srltid=AfmBOopZFBbSGBPHe8cuLFkFqdYoT17sKDB4dE7l_jkNqoWyh_h2cotQ

bus and tram conductors, postal workers, police, firefighters and as bank tellers and clerks. Women were paid less than men for their work in factories; hence, there was a worry that employers would continue to employ women in these jobs even when the men returned from the war. This was not the case as a lot of these women were either laid off to make way for the returning soldiers, or remained working alongside men but at lower wage rates.⁴

Women's Rights Movement

The women's rights movement, a diverse social movement largely based in the United States in the 1960s and 1970s, sought equal rights and opportunities and greater personal freedom for women. With the inclusion of Title IX in the Education Codes of 1972, equal access to higher education and to professional schools became the law. The number of women doctors, lawyers, engineers, architects, and other professionals has doubled and doubled again as quotas limiting women's enrollment in graduate schools were outlawed.



The women's liberation movement.
Source: History Extra

There was significant discrimination in hiring practices as well. Help-wanted ads in newspapers were segregated into 'Help wanted-women' and 'Help wanted-men'. Thus, there were several jobs that women were unable to apply for. The Equal Employment Opportunity Commission (EEOC) ruled this illegal in 1968, but since the EEOC had little enforcement power at the time, most newspapers ignored the requirement for years.⁵ Several civil society organisations, such as The National Organisation for Women (NOW), advocated for women's workplace rights, taking the issue to the Supreme Court to ensure that women could hold any job for which they are qualified. This paved the way for the growing participation rates seen today.⁶

INFLUENCING FACTORS

Social and Cultural Norms

Restrictive Gender Roles

One of the barriers to women's economic empowerment and labour market participation is the restrictive gender norms relating to the acceptability of women working outside the home and the division of care and domestic work responsibilities inside the home. These norms stem from deep-rooted traditional gender roles that restrict women's career opportunities. Societal expectations mainly mould male counterparts to be primary breadwinners, while women are expected to focus on raising children and carry out household chores.

Globally, women spend around 4.4 hours/day carrying out unpaid work in comparison to men's

⁴ *Striking women*. World War I: 1914-1918 | Striking Women. (n.d.). <https://www.striking-women.org/module/women-and-work/world-war-i-1914-1918>

⁵ California Advisory Committee to the U.S. Commission on Civil Rights. (1978, September). *Behind the scenes: Equal employment opportunity in the motion picture industry*. U.S. Commission on Civil Rights. <https://www2.law.umaryland.edu/marshall/usccr/documents/cr12em712.pdf>

⁶ *History of the women's rights movement*. National Women's History Alliance. (2019, November 5). <https://nationalwomenshistoryalliance.org/history-of-the-womens-rights-movement/>

1.4 hours/day.⁷ Unpaid care and domestic work are a pressing challenge, with an estimated 708 million women worldwide outside the labour force because of unpaid care responsibilities.⁸ This not only locks women out of the labour force but also minimises the economic potential of those already in the labour force.

Developing Countries

In developing countries, high female labour force participation often reflects poverty, where women join the workforce as a coping mechanism during economic shocks. This is also because these societies often maintain more rigid traditional and patriarchal structures, which limit women's participation further.

Norms about whether women should work are strongly bound up with cultural values about decorum and respectability. In South Asia, in particular, this generally implied a preference for women working from home, in prestigious female-dominated activities such as tutoring, or not engaging in paid work. Barriers identified include fear of gossip and reputational risks associated with going out alone, as well as for their daughters' reputation and safety. In Central and East Africa, women's involvement in some forms of mining was felt to contravene norms related to contact between men and women, and of decorum and appropriate dress. Thus, such social norms and structures may be the most influential and unspoken barriers to women's economic empowerment.⁹

Limited Access

Education

Education enhances productivity, employability and income-earning potential. Less educated women tend to have limited access to wage work and are often confined to home-based self-employment or unpaid family work, if they participate in the labour force at all.¹⁰ Without access to adequate education, women lack the necessary skills for higher-paying, formal jobs, thus making them less competitive in the labour market.

Educated women are more likely to participate in the formal labour market and earn higher incomes. A 2018 World Bank study estimates that the limited educational opportunities for girls and barriers to completing 12 years of education cost countries between USD 15 trillion and 30 trillion in lost lifetime productivity and earnings.¹¹

Education also equips women with the skills needed for leadership roles, enabling them to advocate for policies that improve family and community life, such as better education and social services.

Financial Literacy

Financial literacy refers to the diverse knowledge and skills on financial matters, such as managing money, setting budgets, and investing. Advocating financial literacy among women is instrumental in imparting knowledge and

⁷ Sarasanti, N., Donkor, F. K., Santos, C., Tsagkari, M., & Wannous, C. (2020). It's about time we care about an equitable world: Women's unpaid care work and COVID-19. *IEEE Engineering Management Review*, 48(4), 37–45. <https://doi.org/10.1109/EMR.2020.3031313>

⁸ International Labour Organization. (2024, October). *The impact of care responsibilities on women's labour force participation* [Statistical Brief]. https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/2024-10/GEDI-STAT%20brief_formatted_28.10.24_final.pdf

⁹ Social Norms and women's economic empowerment. (n.d.). <https://idl-bnc-idrc.dspacedirect.org/server/api/core/bitstreams/9b717b23-7c59-4274-82ed-f4308ee2fo4c/content>

¹⁰ Explaining the MENA paradox: Rising educational attainment yet stagnant female labor force participation. (n.d.-a). <https://www.demographic-research.org/volumes/vol43/28/43-28.pdf>

¹¹ World Bank Group. (2018, July 11). *Not educating girls costs countries trillions of dollars, says New World Bank Report*. World Bank. <https://www.worldbank.org/en/news/press-release/2018/07/11/not-educating-girls-costs-countries-trillions-of-dollars-says-new-world-bank-report>

comprehension of intricate financial concepts and practices, such as cash flows, saving, investing, and debt management.¹²

Women face several barriers that impede their access to financial services. Factors such as lack of access to financial institutions, lack of formal identification documents, societal norms and cultural constraints often discourage women from utilising financial products. Unequal access to technology exacerbates demand-side barriers for women in accessing financial services. Limited ownership of smartphones, digital illiteracy, and restricted internet access disproportionately affect women, hindering their ability to engage with modern financial tools. Many women entrepreneurs do not even apply for loans because of low financial literacy, risk aversion, or fear of failure.¹³

Women with higher financial literacy rates start businesses at significantly higher rates than those without such knowledge. Understanding cash flow management, profit calculations, and basic accounting enables women to move from subsistence activities to scalable enterprises.

Financial literacy also aids in retirement planning, without which women may face financial insecurity in the long term, leading to dependence on others or social security benefits, reducing autonomy.

Workplace Issues

Safety

Globally, women are disproportionately impacted by gender-based violence, including sexual harassment and assault at work. This not

only undermines their physical and psychological safety and well-being but also hinders their ability to work in a secure manner. Millions of female workers are forced to work in an intimidating, hostile or humiliating environment, and experience various unwelcome forms of sexual conduct. A third of women are extremely concerned about their personal safety when at work, and about 20% report having been harassed, stalked, or made to feel uncomfortable at work by colleagues or clients.¹⁴ Women also frequently report experiencing non-inclusive behaviours at work, including bullying, receiving inappropriate comments or microaggressions. Such behaviours can often be dismissed or minimised, making it more difficult for women to report these occurrences to higher authorities.

Gender Pay Gap

The gender pay gap, estimated at around 20% globally, has a significant impact on women's economic empowerment. It reduces their earning potential, making it more difficult for women to achieve financial autonomy and security. This wage disparity is not only a consequence of unequal pay for equal work but also reflects deeper structural inequalities, including occupational segregation, where women are disproportionately employed in lower-paying sectors and positions. As a result, women are more likely to occupy low-paying jobs, and the gender pay gap exacerbates this situation, limiting their opportunities for upward mobility and career advancement. This makes it difficult for women to provide for themselves and their families and can lead to poverty and

¹² Sundarasan, S., Rajagopalan, U., Kanapathy, M., & Kamaludin, K. (2023). Women's financial literacy: A bibliometric study on current research and future directions. *Heliyon*, 9(12), e21379. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2023.e21379>

¹³ Morsy, H. (2020). Access to finance – Mind the gender gap. *The Quarterly Review of Economics and Finance*, 78, 12–21. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.qref.2020.02.005>

¹⁴ Deloitte. (2025). *Women at work: A global outlook*. <https://www.deloitte.com/content/dam/assets-shared/docs/collections/2025/deloitte-women-at-work-2025-a-global-outlook.pdf>

financial insecurity.¹⁵ The compounded effect of these factors contributes to persistent economic vulnerability, particularly among marginalised groups, reinforcing cycles of poverty and gendered economic inequality.

Work-Life Balance

Another factor that contributes to lower labour force participation is an inadequate work-life balance. According to the International Labour Organisation (ILO), 47% of women worldwide working full-time for an employer say they would prefer to work at paid jobs and care for their families and home simultaneously. This preference reflects the broader societal expectation that women bear the primary responsibility for caregiving and household duties, a systemic issue that is reinforced by both cultural norms and institutional structures.

A lack of flexible working hours as well as a lack of affordable care for children and relatives leads to fewer opportunities, and thus, a lower rate of participation.¹⁶ The absence of supportive workplace policies, such as flexible hours or paid caregiving leave, further exacerbates gender inequalities by limiting women's ability to balance professional and personal responsibilities.

IMPACTS

Economic Growth

During the second half of the 20th century, most countries experienced a substantial increase in the participation of women in the labour force. As a pure accounting matter, having more women in the labour force should translate into a higher standard, as it means more labour input and hence more aggregate output. Using an international panel that covers over 100 countries between 1980 and 2005, it is estimated that both the growth and level of Female Labour Force Participation (FLFP) have positive effects on economic growth.¹⁷

When women earn, they contribute to the household income, which directly improves living standards. Certain studies have shown that when women work, the GDP of a region rises significantly, and that means that women can contribute not only to the betterment of their own homes but also to the economic growth of the country. Moreover, financially independent women are more likely to encourage their children to pursue education, breaking intergenerational cycles of poverty.¹⁸

¹⁵ Reshi, I. A., & Sudha, T. (2025). The gender pay gap and its impact on women's economic empowerment. *Multidisciplinary Output Research for Actual and International Issues (MORFAI Journal)*, 1(1), 9–18.

<https://pdfs.semanticscholar.org/ab2f/6ffeff485a705064adc262e44e4ba04c5f1b.pdf>

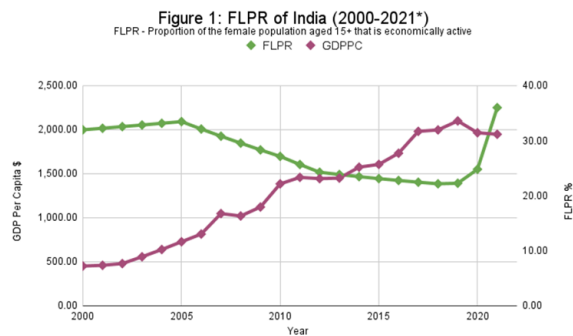
¹⁶ full-time International Labour Organization. (2017). *Towards a better future for women and work: Voices of women and men*.

https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/wcmsp5/groups/public/@dgreports/@dcomm/@publ/documents/publication/wcms_546256.pdf

¹⁷ Female labor force participation and economic growth: Accounting for the gender bonus - sciencedirect. (n.d.). <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0165176521000173>

¹⁸ *The impact of financial autonomy on women's confidence and community roles*. ProjectChirag. (2025, March 13).

<https://projectchirag.org/the-impact-of-financial-independence-on-womens-confidence-and-community-roles/>



Women's Labour Force Participation Paradox in India.

Source: Centre for Public Policy Research

Development of Society

As more women find employment opportunities, nations witness a steady march towards gender equality. Women's increasing financial autonomy creates a ripple effect that uplifts families and communities, bringing about meaningful social change. When women contribute financially to their households, families are often able to invest more in education, access better healthcare, and explore new opportunities. This empowerment is transformative. Financially independent women are more likely to make decisions that benefit their children's futures, and communities gain when women have the resources and influence to create lasting positive impacts. The shift towards a more equitable workforce enriches the social fabric, setting a foundation for inclusive growth.¹⁹

Personal Empowerment

Financial autonomy gives women control over their lives, allowing them to make decisions about their education, healthcare, and future. Because there is a reduced dependence on male family members, there is a greater sense of self-worth and confidence in them. Women may

choose to invest a larger portion of their income in their families, especially in children's education, nutrition, and health, which in turn will lead to healthier and better-educated families. A financially independent woman can also provide a safety net during economic hardships, reducing family vulnerability and challenging patriarchal norms, creating a more gender equitable home and society. Financial autonomy empowers women to participate in decision-making processes within their families and communities. Thus, it enables them to pursue higher goals and encourages other women in their communities to do the same.²⁰

It is found that 46.97% of financially independent women can autonomously make decisions regarding investment in fixed deposits, as compared to 20% of financially dependent women.²¹ This stat shows that financially independent women are more autonomous and make their own decisions. They are more confident, independent, decisive, and disciplined, which are qualities needed in leadership roles. Hence, women's financial empowerment often leads to leadership roles in self-help groups, cooperatives, and local governance, promoting more inclusive development.

PAST INTERNATIONAL ACTIONS

UN Women

UN Women has spearheaded a range of global initiatives to promote women's economic empowerment.

The Women's Empowerment Principles (WEPs), developed jointly by UN Women and UN Global

¹⁹ India's workforce transformation: A rising tide of female participation. (n.d.-b).

<https://www.pib.gov.in/FeaturesDeatils.aspx?NotelD=153426&ModuleId=2>

²⁰ The impact of financial autonomy on women's confidence and community roles. ProjectChirag. (2025, March 13).

<https://projectchirag.org/the-impact-of-financial-independence-on-womens-confidence-and-community-roles/>

²¹ (N.d.-e). <https://ajmjournal.com/HTMLPaper.aspx?Journal=Asian+Journal+of+Management%3BPID%3D2024-15-3-8;>

Compact, are a set of principles offering guidance to businesses on how to advance gender equality and women's empowerment in the workplace, marketplace and community. Informed by international labour and human rights standards, they provide a seven-point framework for companies to promote gender equality at work: equal pay, leadership opportunities, and inclusive supply chains.²² Another initiative, implemented jointly by UN Women and other bodies such as the Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO), is the Joint Programme on Accelerating Progress Towards Rural Women's Economic Empowerment (JP RWEE). This is a global initiative focused on securing rural women's livelihoods, rights and resilience in the context of sustainable development, Agenda 2030 and the SDGs. It works to improve the status of women and rural communities by enhancing food security and nutrition, increasing income and economic autonomy, and promoting participation and leadership. The key results of the programme include reaching over 130,000 rural women and men, increasing agricultural production by 82%, and enhancing gender-responsive leadership with 77% of producer organisations led by rural women.²³

CEDAW

The Convention for the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW) was adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in 1979 and has been instrumental in bringing to light all the areas in which women are denied equality with men. Articles 11 and 13 specifically affirm women's rights to non-discrimination in employment and economic activities.

Article 11 of CEDAW requires countries to protect women's rights to work, to ensure that women have the same training and employment opportunities as men, that women receive equal pay for work of equal value, that women have access to the same benefits, compensatory schemes, and allowances as men, especially in relation to retirement and incapacity to work. Article 13 of CEDAW expressly requires that women have equal access to family benefits, forms of financial credit, including mortgages, and the same rights as men to participate in recreational activities and cultural life.²⁴ CEDAW also encourages the provision of social services such as childcare, vocational training, and education, which are crucial for women to balance economic and domestic responsibilities. These measures help reduce structural constraints that often confine women to informal or low-paid work.

International Labour Organisation

The International Labour Organisation (ILO) has been committed to promoting gender equality in the workplace, with several conventions addressing the need for equal opportunities and rights in the workplace for men and women.

Convention 100- Equal Remuneration Convention (1951) requires all member states to adhere to the principle of equal remuneration for men and women workers for work of equal value. It emphasises the elimination of the gender pay

²² UN Women. (2022). *Equality means business: Women's Empowerment Principles (WEPs) brochure*.

https://www.weps.org/sites/default/files/2022-12/WEPS%20BROCHURE%20%28december%202022%29_o.pdf

²³ Joint Programme on Accelerating Progress Towards Rural Women's Economic Empowerment (JP RWEE). (2025). *JP RWEE factsheet – September 2025*. <https://jprwee.org/sites/default/files/2025-09/JP%20RWEE%20Factsheet%20-%20September%202025.pdf>

²⁴ *Woman of the world - A guide to the rights in CEDAW*. The Australian Human Rights Commission. (n.d.). <https://humanrights.gov.au/our-work/publications/woman-world-guide-rights-cedaw>

gap, thus promoting women's economic autonomy.²⁵

Convention 156- Workers with Family Responsibilities Convention (1981), as well as Convention 183- Maternity Protection Convention, 2000, both focus on promoting a work environment that recognises the critical role of workers' family obligations while ensuring job security. C156 emphasises the need for Members to enable persons with family responsibilities who are engaged or wish to engage in employment to exercise their right to do so without being subject to discrimination.²⁶ C183 focuses on providing essential maternity and postpartum leave while protecting their employment rights, including protection from dismissal and access to adequate medical and cash benefits.²⁷

CASE STUDIES

Post-Genocide Rwanda

The tragedy of the 1994 Rwandan genocide changed the gender balance of the Rwandan society. Gender equality was made a national priority by the government, which was formed by the Rwandan Patriotic Front after the genocide. In 1999, the parliament passed a law, known as the Matrimonial and Succession law, which provided women equal rights to property, inheritance, and ownership of assets in marriage.

The Rwandan genocide provided context for countless women's rights movements in Rwanda. Women emerged as resilient agents of change in its aftermath. In the wake of the genocide, Rwanda faced the daunting task of rebuilding a shattered society and fostering reconciliation among its fractured communities. Women played a central role in this process, contributing to efforts in reconciliation, peacebuilding, and socioeconomic development.

Additionally, the government implemented policies to ensure gender equality and equity, including the constitution formalising the inclusion of women in decision-making capacities and laws supporting education for all and eradicating discrimination.

This comprehensive approach to gender equality and women's empowerment led to measurable progress, with women actively participating in political, social, economic, and cultural domains of life. Rwanda's post-genocide gender mainstreaming efforts have resulted in impressive progress, with a higher ratio of women in parliament than in any other African country since 2003.²⁸

The Labour force participation rate of females above 15 years in Rwanda in 2024 was 57.87% according to the World Bank Group. It has been increasing in the past three decades. The rate of

²⁵ International Labour Organization. (1951). *Equal Remuneration Convention*, 1951 (No. 100).

https://normlex.ilo.org/dyn/nrmlx_en/f?p=NORMLEXPUB:12100:0::NO::P12100_ILO_CODE:C100

²⁶ Convention C156 - Workers with Family Responsibilities Convention, 1981 (No. 156). (n.d.).

https://normlex.ilo.org/dyn/nrmlx_en/f?p=NORMLEXPUB%3A12100%3Ao%3A%3ANO%3A%3AP12100_ILO_CODE%3AC156

²⁷ Convention C100 - Equal Remuneration Convention, 1951 (No. 100). (n.d.).

https://normlex.ilo.org/dyn/nrmlx_en/f?p=NORMLEXPUB%3A12100%3Ao%3A%3ANO%3A%3AP12100_ILO_CODE%3AC100

²⁸ Gonzalez, A., Fuenzalida, I., Likins, M., Lambert, A., Diaz, J. C., Promero, Thomson, S., Khan, S., & McGonigal, S. (n.d.). *Women's impact in a post-genocide rwanda: Efforts towards reconciliation and progress*. Collective and Subjective Knowledges: A Transnational Feminist Essay Collective.

<https://pressbooks.claremont.edu/gws183transfemtheories2024/chapter/petra-romero-womens-movements-in-post-genocide-rwanda/>

participation in the labour force in 2010 was 54.33% and in 2000, the rate was 53.67%.



Grassroots initiatives empowering Rwandan women.
Source: Women for Women International

Afghanistan, Since the Taliban

Since taking control of Afghanistan, the Taliban have enforced strict policies that have restricted women's access to work, banned them from secondary and higher education, and created huge barriers to women's health. Female employment levels in Afghanistan have fallen steeply since the Taliban administration took over in 2021 and introduced these policies, according to new figures released by the International Labour Organisation (ILO). In the fourth quarter of 2022, female employment is estimated to have been 25 per cent lower than in the second quarter of 2021, before the crisis.²⁹

Restrictions on women's participation in the labour market have contributed to the decline. Home-based self-employment has become the predominant form of women's participation in the labour market, which has prevented the figure from falling further.

The labour force participation rate of females above 15 years has fallen in recent years since the Taliban, with the percentage rate of participation in 2024 being 5.1%. The rate of participation in 2020 was 16.47% and the rate of participation just three years before, in 2017, was 21.24%, the highest in the past three decades, according to the World Bank Group. Afghanistan currently has the second-lowest rate of labour force participation of females, only being ahead of the Republic of Yemen.

Iceland

The latest value of the rate of labour force participation of women from 2024 is 70.29 % which has been consistent since 1990, with the average percentage from 1990 to 2024 being 70.31 %. Iceland is far ahead of the global average of 51.13 %, based on data taken from 176 countries.³⁰

In recent times, women's participation in the labour market is almost equal to men's involvement. The large, female-dominated public sector characterises the labour market in the Nordic welfare societies and represents 25-30% of all jobs. In Iceland, 45% of employed women work in public administration, education, health, and social services. This statistic indicates that the traditional roles of women in the home have been moved into the public sector of care work, and this is one of the reasons the Nordic countries are above average on measures of labour market segregation.

In Iceland, the Act on Equal Status and Equal Rights Irrespective of Gender, no. 150/2020, was enforced. Its objective is to work against pay discrimination and other forms of gender-based discrimination in the labour market and enable

²⁹ *Women bear the brunt of Afghanistan job losses*. International Labour Organization. (2024, July 23).

<https://www.ilo.org/resource/news/women-bear-brunt-afghanistan-job-losses>

³⁰ *Labor force participation rate, female (% of female population ages 15+) (modeled ILO estimate) - Rwanda*. World Bank Open Data. (n.d.).

https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/SL.TLF.CACT.FE.ZS?end=2024&locations=RW&name_desc=true&start=1990&type=shaded&view=chart&year=2024

everyone, irrespective of gender, to reconcile their work and family life. Other objectives of the Act include promoting gender-neutral classification of jobs. Special emphasis is placed on equalising the positions of women and men as regards managerial and influential positions.³¹

Iceland has demonstrated significant progress in female labour force participation, consistently ranking among the best in the world for gender equality and women's participation in the workforce. This has led to the development of the economy and society of the nation.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, enhancing women's labour force participation and financial autonomy leads to the

development of society, countries and women worldwide. Although the rate of the involvement of women in the labour force is increasing, it is still low compared to that of men. Social and cultural norms, the limited amount of resources, safety concerns and more such issues act as barriers to achieving this goal.

Financial autonomy makes women more self-reliant, confident and more decisive. It is seen that when women gain access to equal resources, the growth of the country's economy takes place, and women achieve autonomy. Member states need to discuss these barriers and find a solution to achieve this agenda. They should create policies, programs and make resolutions to help women move towards the goal.

³¹ *Equality in the labour market*. (n.d.). <https://www.government.is/topics/human-rights-and-equality/equality/equality-in-the-labour-market/>

Agenda 2: Assessing the Status and Representation of Women in Media

AGENDA OVERVIEW

The representation of women in the media is an important factor that influences gender equality and the empowerment of women. Media influences the mindset of society, shapes the cultural and social norms, and can challenge stereotypes. Although the representation of women in the media is increasing, it is still lower compared to men, especially in leadership roles. Women are also often portrayed stereotypically in movies, news outlets, series and more such platforms. The agenda aims to change this perception of women and increase the representation of women, especially in leadership roles, in the media.

The discussion of this agenda focuses on barriers such as gender pay gaps, discrimination, patriarchy and more, the current situation worldwide, the progress in recent years and the impacts of increasing women's representation in media. The member states should come up with a resolution to increase the representation and status of women in the media.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

Historically, women have faced several barriers in their representation in mainstream media. Female journalists were often relegated to writing on topics related to domestic life, household matters and so on. The late 19th century saw a rise of women-only publications, owed partially to the women's suffrage movement. The 1900s saw some improvement, with better opportunities, yet there remain considerable disparities in newsrooms and editorial roles between men and women.

In film and television, women have historically

been cast in stereotypical roles, exacerbating traditional, harmful gender norms. Although women played a significant role as filmmakers and writers during the silent era, their participation sharply declined with the rise of the studio system in the 1930s, which became increasingly male-dominated.³²

INFLUENCING FACTORS

Institutional Barriers

Gender Pay Gap

In an era where journalism plays a crucial role in upholding democracy and advocating for equality and the public's right to know, women journalists around the world face a troubling reality, wherein, despite representing a significant portion of the journalism workforce, they are consistently paid less than their male counterparts. This inequality undermines not only the rights of women in the workforce but also the credibility and ethical standards of the profession at large.

In Brazil, women journalists employed under a work contract earn on average 5.7% less than men for the same work. This difference increases with the higher the position. For instance, in the case of editors-in-chief, women earn 41.3% less than men in this position. The figures come from a survey commissioned by the Federação Nacional dos Jornalistas (FENAJ). A survey was conducted with 496 Brazilian journalists, and in-depth interviews were conducted with 21 professionals. Results coincide with findings from the literature in the area regarding structural inequalities in the profession: women earn less; they are under-represented in leadership and directorial positions in media companies, while simultaneously being in the

³² Byerly, C. M., & Ross, K. (2006). *Women and media: A critical introduction*. Blackwell Publishing.
<http://ndl.ethernet.edu.et/bitstream/123456789/17633/1/58.pdf.pdf>

majority in less legitimate and more precarious segments of the profession.³³

The gender pay gap globally is estimated at 20%, according to the ILO 2023 Global report. This means that women earn, on average, 80% of what men earn. At the current rate, it will take at least until 2086 to achieve wage equality worldwide, according to estimates by the International Labour Organisation (ILO).³⁴

Soft News

Studies have found that although the number of women working in the media has been increasing globally, the top positions are still very male-dominated. This disparity is particularly evident in Africa, where cultural impediments to women fulfilling the role of journalist, such as travelling away from home, evening work, and covering issues such as politics and sports, which are considered to fall within the masculine domain, remain. The Global Media Monitoring Project (GMMP) reports that throughout the world, female journalists are more likely to be assigned 'soft' subjects such as family, lifestyle, fashion, and arts. The 'hard' news, politics and the economy are much less likely to be written or covered by women. Women are often assigned to cover 'soft beats' such as Lifestyle and Fashion, while men predominate in the 'hard beats'. On average, women's contribution to articles looks like Science and Technology (33.3%), Culture and Entertainment (32.8%), and Public Life (32.6%), while Sports (6%), Defence and National Security (10.5%), and Politics (19.8%). Women appear in 15.7% of all flagship debates and comprise 22.4%

of the panellists on average, far less than the male presence.³⁵

The level of participation and influence of women in the media also has implications for media content: female media professionals are more likely to reflect other women's needs and perspectives than their male colleagues. It is important to acknowledge, however, that not all women working in the media will be gender aware and prone to covering women's needs and perspectives, and it is not impossible for men to effectively cover gender issues. This indicates that women are represented in less than one-sixth of such debates. This underrepresentation illustrates the need for balanced participation in order to include varied perspectives in media.

Harassment

Pay inequality and harassment of women journalists are pervasive around the world. While many journalists may experience online harassment, women journalists are more likely to become victims of it than male journalists. The violence they experience is gender-based. This type of online harassment against women journalists can result in self-censorship, which means that essential information cannot reach the wider public. One in three women journalists even considers leaving the profession because of online harassment.

Training more women journalists means little if the sector fails to retain their talent because, in addition to facing violence and harassment for working in a male-dominated field, they must contend with a glass ceiling that prevents them from reaching decision-making roles, regardless

³³ Journalistic careers and gender in Brazil: Impasses and inequalities between men and women in the profession: Journalism studies: Vol 25 , no 15 - get access. (n.d.-b).

<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/1461670X.2024.2404221?af=R>

³⁴ *Equal pay day: Global gender pay gap in journalism must be addressed immediately* / IFJ. International Federation of Journalists. (2024, September 17). <https://www.ifj.org/media-centre/news/detail/article/equal-pay-day-global-gender-pay-gap-in-journalism-must-be-addressed-immediately>

³⁵ Geostrata, T. (2024, December 9). *Gendered media: Underrepresentation of women*. THE GEOSTRATA. <https://www.thegeostrata.com/post/under-representation-of-women-in-gendered-media>

of their efforts and abilities. Women journalists often face harassment internally within organisations and externally in the broader environment over the course of their work, not only from managers and colleagues but also from sources.

Despite these challenges, successful efforts in some countries illustrate the effectiveness of collaboration to build momentum for policy initiatives that address gender inequality in the media sector. In November 2023, 33 media houses in Rwanda signed up for the Rwanda Media Anti Sexual Harassment Policy, which will be monitored by a committee of media representatives. Local media proposed the initiative so they could refer to a set of guidelines when crafting anti-sexual harassment policies.

The latest draft of the country's national media policy includes language specifying action items for the government that would improve working conditions for women journalists. These include helping media regulators develop an anti-sexual harassment policy, ensuring equal gender representation in the senior management of public media, and launching awareness campaigns to promote gender-sensitive reporting.³⁶

Discrimination

There has been a long-standing tradition of the media's failure to represent women of colour in politics. This lack of intersectional media coverage leads to drastic consequences within the sociopolitical environment and the representation that women of colour ultimately receive. This underrepresentation may, in turn,

lead to viewers adopting similar ideologies of neglect.

The issue of representation begins with the lack thereof. Women of colour in politics receive significantly less media coverage overall and suffer the consequences in their elections as a result. Part of this lack of representation is rooted in the lack of representation of women as politicians in general in the media.

Underrepresentation in Media

Around the world, women are far less likely than men to be seen in the media. As subjects of stories, women only appear in a quarter of television, radio, and print news. In a 2015 report, women made up a mere 19% of experts featured in news stories and 37% of reporters telling stories globally.³⁷

When it comes to equality of men and women in news media, progress has virtually ground to a halt. According to the largest study on the portrayal, participation, and representation of women in the news media spanning 20 years and 114 countries, only 24% of the people heard, read about, or seen in newspapers, television, and radio news are women.

Women in journalism also face underrepresentation in top positions. According to the Women's Media Centre (2019), women make up just 41% of newsroom employees and only 27% of top management positions in the industry.³⁸ Gender biases, lack of opportunity in leadership roles, and cultural expectations are barriers that influence the representation of women in news outlets to a great extent.

³⁶ *Breaking barriers: A whole-of-society approach to gender equality in media development*. Center for International Media Assistance. (2025, January 22). <https://www.cima.ned.org/publication/breaking-barriers-a-whole-of-society-approach-to-gender-equality-in-media-development/>

³⁷ Rattan, A., Chilazi, S., Georgeac, O., & Bohnet, I. (2019, June 6). *Tackling the underrepresentation of women in media*. Harvard Business Review. <https://hbr.org/2019/06/tackling-the-underrepresentation-of-women-in-media>

³⁸ Women journalist in Media Industry. (n.d.-e). <https://www.globalmediajournal.com/open-access/opportunities-and-challenges-for-women-journalist-in-media-industry-a-critical-review.php?aid=93047>

Despite the democratizing promise of digital media, women's poor representation in traditional news media is also reflected in digital news, with women making up only 26% of the people in Internet news stories and media news tweets. Only 4% of traditional news and digital news stories clearly challenge gender stereotypes. Among other factors, stereotypes and the significant underrepresentation of women in the media play a significant role in shaping harmful attitudes of disrespect and violence towards women.

Like other forms of media, film and television have a powerful influence in shaping cultural perceptions and attitudes towards gender and are key to shifting the narrative for the gender equality agenda. Yet, an analysis of popular films across 11 countries found, for example, that 31% of all speaking characters were women and that only 23% featured a female protagonist, a number that closely mirrored the percentage of women filmmakers (21%).³⁹

In sports, girls have 1.3 million fewer opportunities to play high school sports than boys have. Despite recent progress, discrimination based on the gender identity of female athletes persists. Girls in sports may experience bullying, social isolation, negative performance evaluations, or the loss of their starting position.⁴⁰ This trend persists in the viewership and media coverage of women's sports as well. An October 2023 study conducted by The Collective, Wasserman's women-focused practice, found that women's sports now comprise 15% of total sports media coverage, owed in large part to the growth of streaming and social media. While this figure may not be

exemplary, it represents a significant advancement towards media equity.

Societal Barriers

Societal barriers such as gender norms, cultural stereotypes and traditions are significant barriers to achieving an equitable representation of women in media and journalism. They often influence the perception of women's professional roles in such fields, limiting both participation as well as advancement.

Objectification

When women are repeatedly objectified, the media contributes to harmful gender stereotypes that often trivialise violence against girls. In a study of print media, researchers at Wesleyan University found that, on average, across 58 different magazines, 51.8% of advertisements featured objectification of women. However, when women appeared in advertisements in men's magazines, they were objectified 76% of the time. A report by the American Psychological Association (APA) on the sexualisation of girls in the media also found that girls are depicted sexually more often than boys.⁴¹

Consequences of objectification for girls and women in the media include anxiety about appearance, feelings of shame, eating disorders, lower self-esteem, and depression.

Research conducted for the Dove Self-Esteem Project found that only 11% of girls worldwide would call themselves beautiful, and six in ten girls avoid participating in life activities because of concerns regarding their appearance. One-

³⁹ UN Women. (2014, September 22). *UN Women releases global study on women characters in film with the Geena Davis Institute on Gender in Media and The Rockefeller Foundation* [Press release].

<https://www.unwomen.org/en/news/stories/2014/9/geena-davis-study-press-release>

⁴⁰ *girls' participation in sports*. Women's Sports Foundation. (2019, October 11).

<https://www.womenssportsfoundation.org/do-you-know-the-factors-influencing-girls-participation-in-sports/>

⁴¹ Not an object: On Sexualization and Exploitation of Women and girls | unicef USA. (n.d.-b).

<https://www.unicefusa.org/stories/not-object-sexualization-and-exploitation-women-and-girls-o>

third of all 6-year-olds in Japan experience low body confidence. Australian girls list body image as one of their top three worries in life, while 81% of 10-year-old girls in the U.S. say they are afraid of being fat.

Patriarchy

Patriarchy not only grants privileges to men but also enforces gender roles that can limit both men's and women's opportunities in society. Patriarchy influences the representation of women in film by establishing norms that often prioritise male perspectives. This leads to women being depicted primarily as objects or secondary characters rather than as complex individuals with their own narratives. The prevalence of the male gaze in cinematic storytelling reinforces these limited representations and contributes to societal perceptions about women's roles and identities.

Patriarchal representations in film significantly impact societal views regarding gender roles by normalising stereotypes that define what is considered acceptable behaviour for men and women. When films consistently portray women in subordinate or objectified positions, it reinforces public perceptions that these roles are natural or expected. Conversely, films that showcase empowered female characters can disrupt these narratives and promote more equitable views on gender roles, contributing to social change over time. Films can reflect dominant patriarchal ideologies by portraying women in stereotypical roles that reinforce traditional gender norms.

However, some films actively challenge these ideologies by presenting strong female protagonists who defy societal expectations. By

doing so, they encourage audiences to question the established norms of patriarchy and inspire discussions around gender equality and representation in media.⁴²

Social Media

The internet makes it relatively easy to access adult content, often without effective age restrictions or parental controls. Young people are often more adept at using technology, which can help them bypass filters and restrictions. A UNESCO report suggests that social media worsens gender stereotypes with a negative impact on girls' career choices.⁴³

On 31 January 2024, a heated Senate Judiciary Committee hearing was held on online child safety. The Chief Executive Officers of Meta, TikTok, Snap, X and Discord faced four hours of intense questioning from the Senate Judiciary Committee. The hearing mentioned five bills whose goals aim at keeping children safe online and opening the doors to hold tech companies accountable for the children they attract to their websites. Their calls for accountability were met with thunderous applause from the families, underscoring the emotional weight of the discussion. In a poignant moment, Mark Zuckerberg, CEO of Meta, stood apart. He directly addressed the families, offering a heartfelt apology for their pain and loss. Zuckerberg offered his apologies, stating, "I'm sorry for everything you have all gone through. No one should go through the things that your families have suffered." He further acknowledged the company's responsibility and highlighted ongoing efforts to invest in safety measures and collaborate with industry experts.⁴⁴

⁴² Patriarchy - (film and media theory) - vocab, definition, explanations. Fiveable. (n.d.).

⁴³ UNESCO. (2024). *Global Education Monitoring Report 2024: Gender report – Technology on her terms*. UNESCO. <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000389406>

⁴⁴ Jagranjosh.com. (2024, February 1). Jagranjosh.com. <https://www.jagranjosh.com/general-knowledge/why-did-mark-zuckerberg-apologise-to-families-during-a-hearing-1706794359-1>

Lack of verification in social media may lead to cyberbullying, exposure to age-inappropriate content, social isolation, and negative mental health outcomes like depression, anxiety, and low self-esteem. Younger children may encounter violent, inappropriate, or misleading content not suitable for their developmental stage, which may shape their perceptions and behaviours negatively.

These issues contribute to the harmful representation of women in the media. The easy access and lack of verification on social media platforms lead to the objectification of women and the reinforcement of stereotypes. Such influence shapes the audience's perception of gender roles and expectations of women. The presence of cyberbullying also adds pressure on women to follow the narrow ideals of femininity. This not only undermines women's self-worth and mental well-being but also limits the visibility of diverse, authentic, and empowered female voices in the media landscape.

In conclusion, the nature of online social media platforms continues to add to the challenges surrounding the representation of women in media. The accessibility of harmful content and the lack of accountability of social media platforms reinforce the stereotypes and foster environments that compromise the representation of women.

IMPACTS

Media Quality and Perpetuation of Norms

The media plays a crucial role in shaping norms and societal perceptions, especially around gender. An insufficient representation of women in the media leads to narratives being dominated

by men. This may reinforce societal norms and gender-based stereotypes, which contribute directly to sexism, discrimination and gender inequality by influencing how women are regarded in the workforce and society, directly affecting their professional opportunities as well as their personal well-being. This may lead to women being discouraged from pursuing such roles in the media, thus perpetuating a harmful cycle.

Women's portrayals have been hypothesised to lead to negative effects on people's well-being on a mental and physical level, as well as bearing partial responsibility for several social issues, such as sexism, gender discrimination and harassment.⁴⁵ Viewing material that is sexually objectifying can contribute to body dissatisfaction, eating disorders, low self-esteem, depressive affect, and even physical health problems for girls and young women.⁴⁶ Furthermore, these portrayals can normalise violence and harassment against women by embedding sexist attitudes into cultural narratives.

Protection, Safety and Well Being

Globally, women journalists and media workers face increasing offline and online attacks and are subject to disproportional and specific threats. Violence committed against female journalists as a result of their work has particular characteristics stemming from the social constructs of gender and discrimination to which women have traditionally been subjected. The gender-based violence they are exposed to implies stigmatisation, sexist hate speech, trolling, physical assault, rape and even murder.

⁴⁵ Santoniccolo, F., Trombetta, T., Paradiso, M. N., & Rollè, L. (2023). Gender and Media Representations: A Review of the Literature on Gender Stereotypes, Objectification and Sexualization. *International journal of environmental research and public health*, 20(10), 5770. <https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph20105770>

⁴⁶ American Psychological Association. (2007). *Report of the APA task force on the sexualization of girls*. <https://www.apa.org/pi/women/programs/girls/report-full.pdf>

Online attacks on women journalists appear to be increasing significantly, entailing misogynistic comments, hate speech and threats of sexual violence and murder. A study by UNESCO found that nearly three-quarters (73%) of women respondents said they had experienced online violence. 20% of respondents also said they had been attacked or abused offline in connection with online violence they had experienced.⁴⁷

A study of journalists by the International Women's Media Foundation (IWMF) found that 58% of women respondents reported being threatened or harassed in person, while 26% were physically attacked.⁴⁸ These statistics reflect a global trend of increasing violence and targeted harassment faced by women journalists, both online and offline. In conflict zones specifically, women reporters are denied access, but also exposed to sexual assault, blackmail, and threats when they do manage to enter.

Biased Media

An underrepresentation of women in newsrooms and decision-making roles undermines the diversity of narratives presented to the public and leads to a biased media landscape that may fail to accurately report on issues vital to women. On a global scale, news coverage appears to mostly feature men, especially when considering representation as expert voices, where women are still underrepresented (24%) despite a rise in coverage in the last 5 years.⁴⁹ This marginalisation of women's voices in prominent media limits diverse perspectives and discourse, indirectly influencing which issues are to be covered.

This underrepresentation also affects the way women view themselves, reinforcing the belief

that they are less qualified or capable of taking on executive roles. The aforementioned IWMF study also found that approximately 40% of respondents said they avoided reporting certain stories as a result of online harassment. This form of self-censorship threatens press freedom and narrows public discourse.

Biased media may lead to the misrepresentation of women and their issues, creating a feedback loop wherein women are discouraged from pursuing careers in journalism and media. This leads to a cycle of disparity that hampers both women's professional opportunities and an equitable media landscape.

PAST ACTIONS

UNESCO

The media has a significant impact on shaping our thoughts and actions, reflecting, and influencing societal structures and systems. It holds power over our understanding of gender, including norms, roles, and stereotypes. Gender norms, or societal expectations and standards that determine how individuals should behave and fulfil specific roles based on their perceived gender, play a crucial role in the distribution of power within society. These norms are also reflected in media structures such as organisations, associations, and newsrooms.

To address this, UNESCO is committed to promoting gender equality within and through the media. The Organisation aims to achieve this by fostering gender equality in media content, enhancing media coverage of gender-related issues, implementing and enhancing gender-responsive reporting practices across all thematic

⁴⁷ UNESCO. (2021). *The chilling: Global trends in online violence against women journalists; research discussion paper* (CI-2021/FEJ/PI/1). <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000377223>

⁴⁸ International Women's Media Foundation & Troll-Busters. (2018). *Attacks and harassment: The impact on female journalists and their reporting*. [https://www.iwmf.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/09/Atta marginalisationcks-and-Harassment.pdf](https://www.iwmf.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/09/Atta%20marginalisationcks-and-Harassment.pdf)

⁴⁹ Macharia, S. (Ed.). (2020). *Who makes the news? Global Media Monitoring Project 2020*. Global Media Monitoring Project. https://whomakesthenews.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/11/GMMP2020.ENG_FINAL.pdf

areas, and promoting gender equity and equality in newsrooms.

UNESCO advocates for the safety of women journalists and collaborates with partners to identify and implement best practices, sharing recommendations with all parties involved in countering attacks against women journalists, as recognised by numerous UN resolutions. They published *The Chilling*, a study on global trends in online violence against women journalists, which demonstrated the extent of attacks against women journalists and the impact on their well-being, their work, and press freedom at large. They are working with partners to develop practical tools for journalists, media managers and newsrooms to respond to online and offline abuse. They have partnered with specialised organisations to train women media workers on the ground and also through massive online training courses, and work with security forces to sensitise them on freedom of expression with a gender focus.⁵⁰

Beijing Platform for Action

In Beijing 1995 conference, UNWomen passed multiple resolutions which included Supporting women's education, training and employment to promote and ensure women's equal access to all areas and levels of the media, Promoting women's full and equal participation in the media, including management, programming, education, training and research, Developing consistent with freedom of expression, regulatory mechanisms, including voluntary ones, that promote balanced and diverse portrayals of women by the media and international communication systems and that promote increased participation by women and

men in production and decision-making, and many more actions to be taken.⁵¹



United Nations Fourth World Conference on Women.

Source: United Nations

These resolutions have since helped women gain more recognition in the media and move towards gender equality. The conference marked a significant turning point for the global agenda for gender equality. The Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, adopted unanimously by 189 countries, was an agenda for women's empowerment that is now considered the key global policy document on gender equality.

The past three decades, since the Beijing conference, have seen significant progress in women's rights and gender equality. Many countries, including Ghana, have implemented policies to address gender based violence and to protect women's rights. According to the Global Media Monitoring Project (GMMP), women constitute 25% of news subjects and interviewees, an increase from 17% in 1995.⁵²

CASE STUDIES

Mexico

Mexico is among the most dangerous countries in the world for reporters and has only been

⁵⁰ Posetti, & Unesco. (1970, January 1). *Safety of Women Journalists*. UNESCO.org. <https://www.unesco.org/en/safety-journalists/safety-women-journalists>

⁵¹ Beijing Declaration and platform for action*. (n.d.-a). <https://www.un.org/womenwatch/daw/beijing/pdf/BDPfA%20E.pdf>

⁵² Rowley, S. (2025, May 13). *beijing+30*. WACC. <https://waccglobal.org/women-and-the-media-stocktaking-realigning-and-reigniting-section-j-at-beijing30/>

surpassed by active war and conflict zones.⁵³ There have been a reported 3,408 attacks against the press between 2018 and 2024, with an average of 40% of these attacks targeting women.⁵⁴ Government preventive measures lack efficacy, and impunity for such violence is widespread. These attacks range from intimidation, harassment, abuse of public power, defamation campaigns on social media, to death threats and sexual violence.

In 2012, the Mexican Congress approved a Law for the Protection of Human Rights Defenders and Journalists, which was made to establish cooperation between the federal government and other entities and municipalities to protect the psychological, moral, and economic integrity of journalists.⁵⁵

The 6-year presidency of Andrés Manuel López Obrador was not able to sufficiently uphold these standards, and the administration failed to prevent impunity for violent crimes against reporters. The current administration, under newly elected President Claudia Sheinbaum, has stated an intent to vigorously uphold the law and reinforce journalist protection mechanisms.⁵⁶

Women journalists in Mexico face uniquely gendered threats and are often forced to self-censor or even relocate entirely. Those who report on issues such as organised crime and state corruption, especially in cartel-dominated regions, face systemic threats of gender-based violence from these cartels. These combined

challenges pose threats both to press freedom and to women's safety.

USA

In the United States of America, both the Hollywood film industry as well as widespread social media use play critical roles in shaping narratives, perpetuating societal norms against women. This is partly owed to the underrepresentation of women in decision-making roles in either industry.

In 2024, 70% of Hollywood films employed 10 or more men in key behind-the-scenes roles, while only 8% employed 10 or more women. Overall, women comprised 23% of all directors, writers, producers, executive producers, editors and cinematographers working on the 250 top-grossing films and 20% on the 100 top films in 2024.⁵⁷ On screen, the average film simply devotes far less screen time to women than men overall, with only 37% of speaking roles going to women in 2022. This underrepresentation in both production and performance roles significantly impacts the narratives portrayed in mainstream Hollywood films.

70% of U.S. teenagers report using social media multiple times per day. Rates of mental health symptoms, including depression, eating disorders, suicidal ideation and behaviour, have risen among adolescents, particularly girls, in

⁵³ Reporters Without Borders. (2024). *2024 Round-up: Journalists killed, detained, held hostage and missing* [PDF]. <https://rsf.org/sites/default/files/medias/file/2024/12/RSF%20Round-up%202024%20EN>

⁵⁴ ARTICLE 19. (2024). *Pending rights: Six-year report on freedom of expression and the right to information in Mexico*. <https://articulo19.org/derechospendientes/>

⁵⁵ Focus: The Observatory on Public Policies for Defenders. (2012, June 25). *Mexico: Decree enacting the Law for the Protection of Human Rights Defenders and Journalists*. <https://www.focus-obs.org/documents/mexico-law-for-the-protection-of-human-rights-defenders-and-journalists/>

⁵⁶ International Press Institute. (2024, May 7). *Gender-based attacks on journalists in Mexico: Will Mexico's first female president bring change?* <https://ipi.media/gender-based-attacks-on-journalists-in-mexico-will-mexicos-first-female-president-bring-change/>

⁵⁷ Lauzen, M. M. (2025). *The Celluloid Ceiling: Employment of behind-the-scenes women on top grossing U.S. films in 2024* (27th Annual Edition). Center for the Study of Women in Television & Film, San Diego State University. <https://womenintvfilm.sdsu.edu/wp-content/uploads/2025/01/2024-Celluloid-Ceiling-Report.pdf>

recent years.⁵⁸ Nearly half of adolescent girls have engaged in disordered eating at least once, which is often a result of viewing unrealistic standards of women in mainstream media, leading to feelings of body dissatisfaction and low self-esteem.

Khabar Lahariya

Khabar Lahariya, Hindi for 'News Waves', is an Indian news brand which is written, edited, illustrated, produced, and marketed by rural, lower-caste women in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.⁵⁹

It was first launched by the Delhi-based NGO Nirantar in 2002 as a way to empower women locally and to serve one of the poorest and least developed regions in India, covering local news with a focus on issues usually neglected. The newspaper received UNESCO's Kim Sejeong Literacy Prize in 2009 for its efforts in promoting literacy amidst marginalised communities.⁶⁰

The paper was first conceived as a literacy project, the success of which pushed them to expand and challenge the very idea of journalism. The organisation trains women in journalism, photography, and multimedia, building their skills and confidence to report on local issues, helping them gain independence and take on leadership roles. These women are economically empowered as well, with some of them being key earners in their families.

CONCLUSION

The media can either support existing social inequities or contest them, and there continues to be a considerable inequity in a gender-focused context. Restrictions on the portrayal of women

in the media come from systemic impediments, deeply embedded stereotypes, and the unequal participation of women. Such portrayals further undermine the safety, opportunities, and cultural narratives of women, resulting in a continued trend of discrimination against women. The pervasive lack of safety for women journalists and media workers from violence and harassment, both online and offline, not only threatens their safety and well-being but may also lead to a harmful culture of impunity and censorship.

These patterns of systemic underrepresentation and negative portrayal are detrimental to media narratives as well as the global pursuit of gender equity. Consequently, women around the world face the repercussions of inequity as these narratives frequently reinforce, rather than challenge, this systemic discrimination.

⁵⁸ Choukas-Bradley, S., Roberts, S. R., Maheux, A. J., & Nesi, J. (2022). The Perfect Storm: A Developmental-Sociocultural Framework for the Role of Social Media in Adolescent Girls' Body Image Concerns and Mental Health. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10567-022-00404-5>

⁵⁹ Sambrook, R., & Kaur, P. (2017). *Digital journalism start-ups in India*. Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism. https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/sites/default/files/2017-04/Digital%20Journalism%20Start-ups%20in%20India_o.pdf#top-grossing

⁶⁰ UNESCO. (2012). *Gender equality and media: A global report*. <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000183809>